

Fact-Checking²

In this context, we are talking about fact-checking that is done before a source is published. Over the last two decades there has been an increase in fact checking as an activity that takes place after a source has been published, a practice discussed in more detail in the chapter, [SIFTing Information](#).

Fact checkers verify that the names, dates, and facts in a work (usually an article or book) are correct. For example, they may contact a person who is quoted in a proposed news article and ask the person whether this quotation is correct, or how to spell the person's name. Fact-checkers are primarily useful in catching accidental mistakes.

The number of people employed in fact-checking varies by publication. Some organizations have substantial fact-checking departments. Others may hire freelancers per piece, or may combine fact-checking with other duties. Magazines are more likely to use fact checkers than newspapers. Television and radio programs rarely employ dedicated fact checkers, and instead expect others, including senior staff, to engage in fact-checking in addition to their other duties.

2. Content in this section is adapted from the Wikipedia entry “Fact-checking” (<https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Fact-checking>) and is used under a CC BY-SA 3.0 license.